When do footballers peak, and when does the market get it wrong?

I built **Peak Window**, a scouting tool with age curves for every position, based on **7,188 players** across Europe's big five leagues.

Colin Spelman

Swipe →

Comparing each player to himself, one season later

I tracked **12,881 year-over-year changes** (2017/18–2024/25), weighted by minutes, and chained them into a curve for each position.

1

Position-specific ratings

Strikers on xG, xAG and shots; centre-backs on aerials, duels and passing; and so on.

2

Survivorship correction

Players who drop out of the big five stay in the data, so older players don't look better than they are.

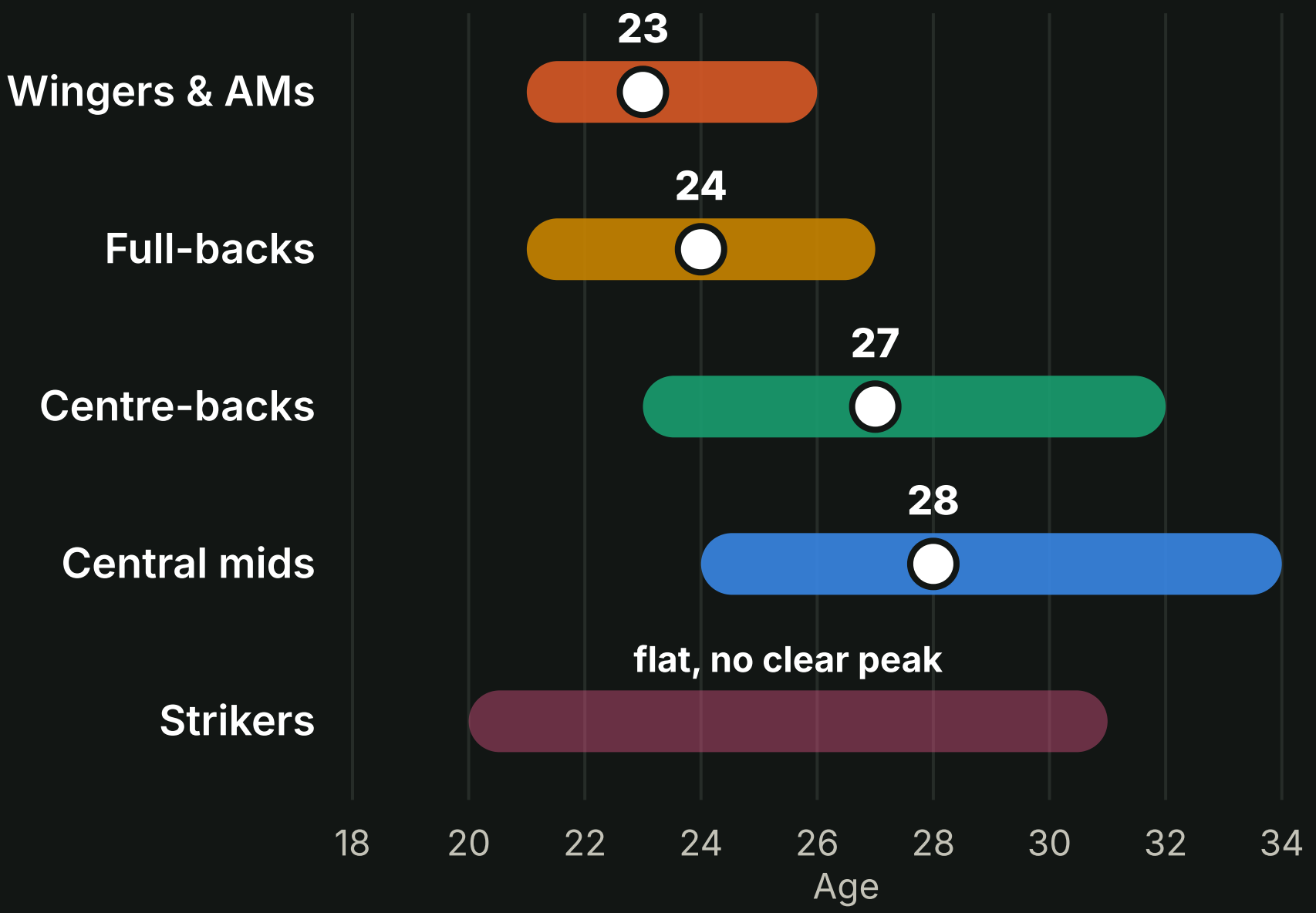
3

Context controls

Adjusts for moving to a stronger or weaker club and for season-wide stat changes.

Every position peaks at a different age

Bars show each position's **peak plateau** (within 1.5 rating points of its best). Dots mark the peak.

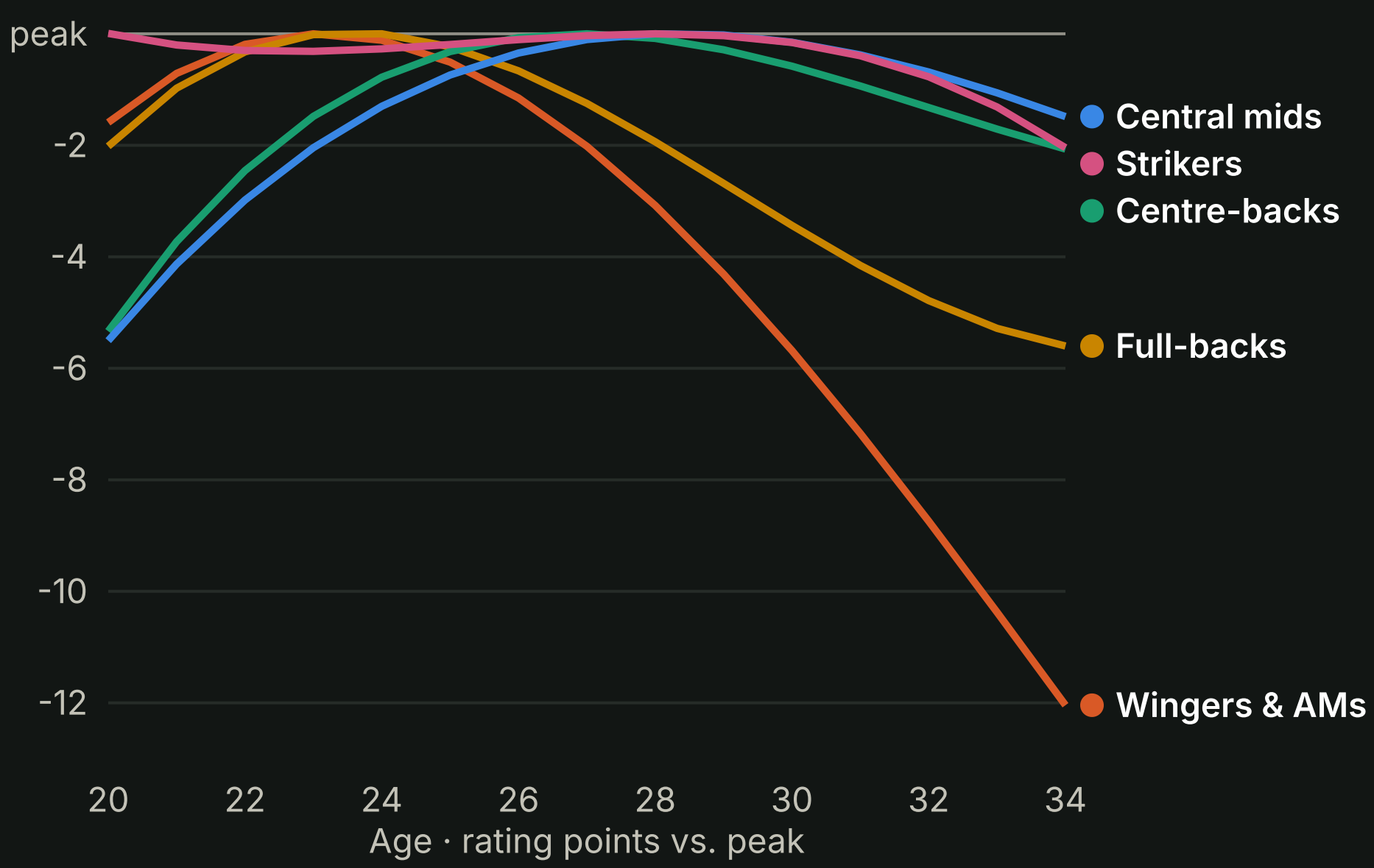


7,188 players · big-five leagues

FBref / Opta 2017/18–2024/25

Wingers fade fastest.
Midfielders barely fade at all.

Rating relative to each position's peak. By 30, a typical winger is **5.7 points** down; a central midfielder just **0.2**.

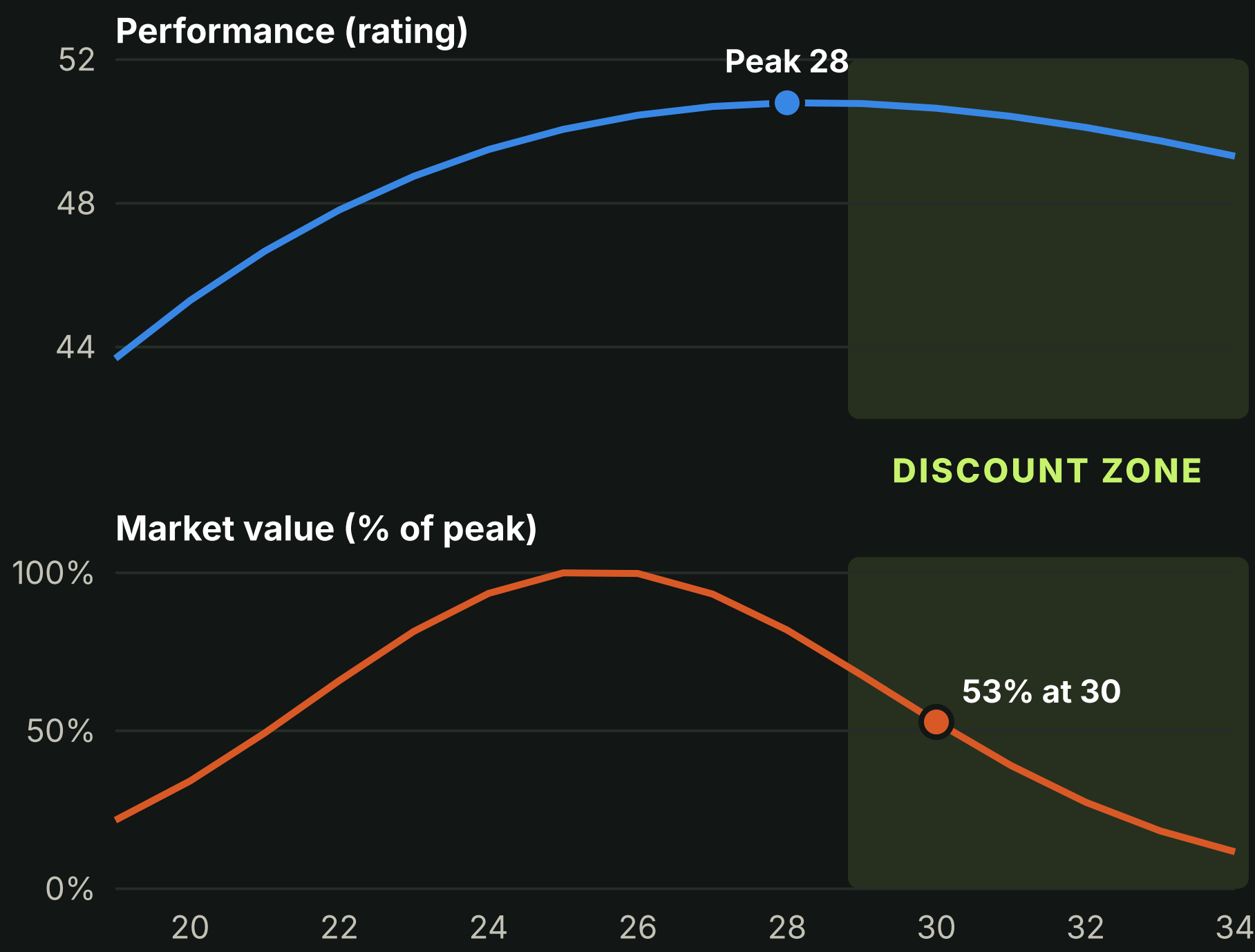


Typical big-five regular · survivorship-corrected

FBref / Opta

Performance holds. Value doesn't.

Central midfielders: output stays near peak into the early 30s, but market value peaks at 25 and halves by 30.

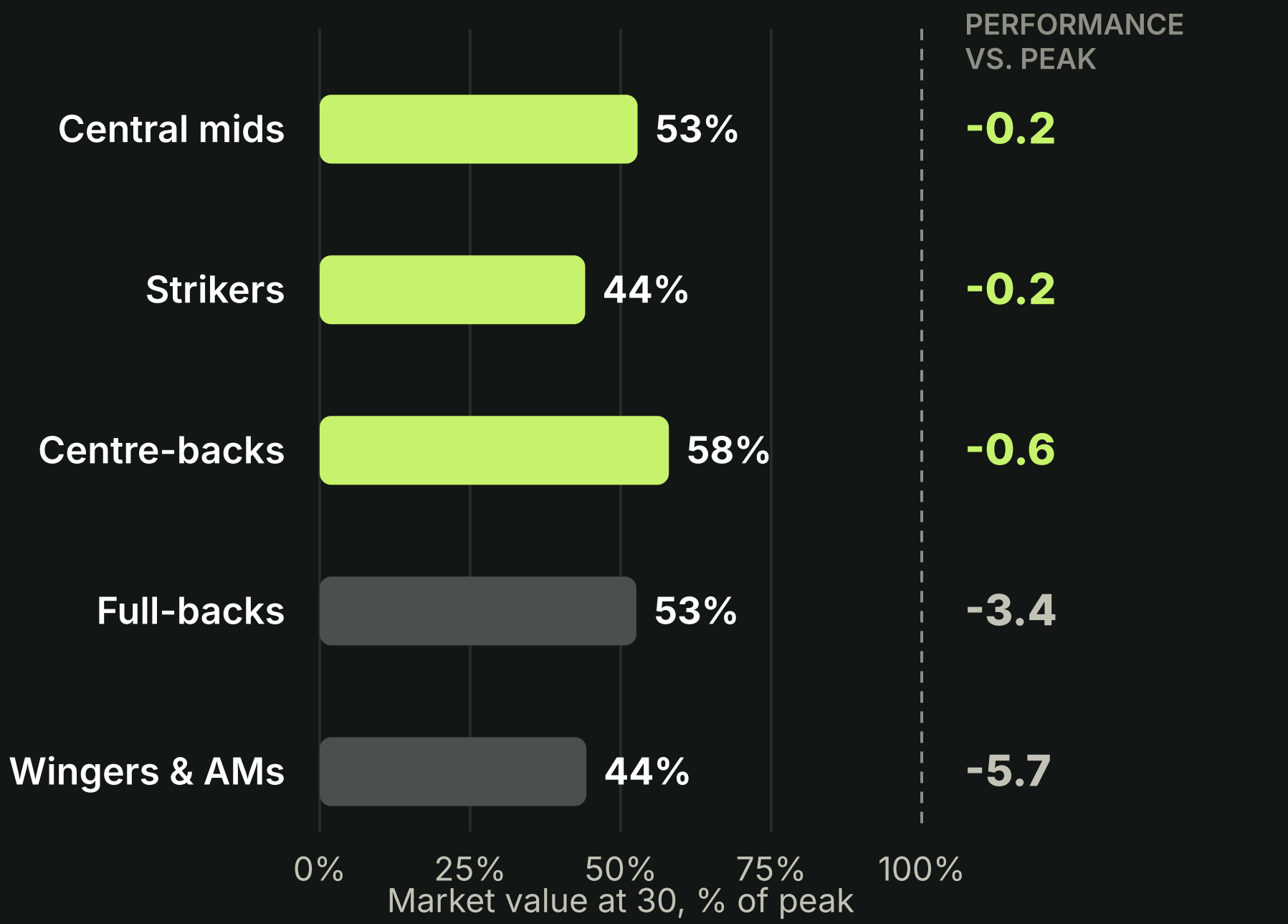


Shaded = discount zone (near-peak output, value ≤ 70% of peak)

Opta · Transfermarkt

Where the market overreacts to age

Market value at 30 (% of peak) vs. how far performance has actually fallen.

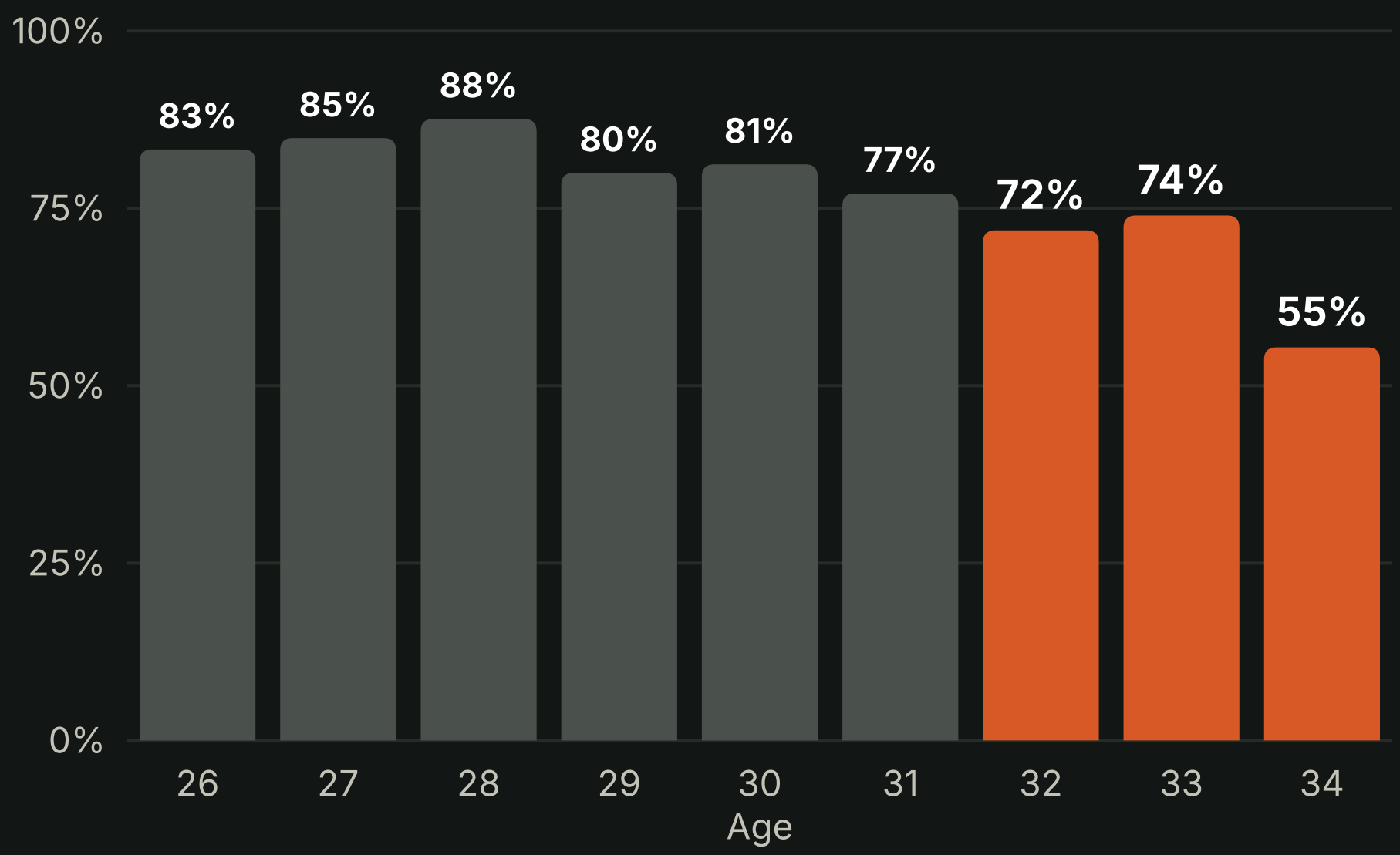


Rating points vs. peak · 10 points = 1 SD

Opta · Transfermarkt 2010–2022

Buy at 28–30, but plan for the exit

Share of regular central midfielders still playing big-five football the following season. It drops below 75% from 32, and to 55% at 34.



Central midfielders · 900+ minutes

FBref / Opta 2017/18–2023/24

The highest projected ceilings among under-21s

2024/25 rating → projected peak, using each player's position curve.



Ratings regressed for sample size · 900+ min

FBref / Opta 2024/25

How I'd use this in a recruitment meeting

1. **Buy midfielders, centre-backs and strikers at 28–30**

   Output is near peak; the price is half.

2. **Sell wingers and full-backs by 26**

   They peak earliest (23–24) and decline fastest.

3. **Price in exit risk after 32**

   Barely half of midfielders aged 34 are still in the big five a year later.

Peak Window also projects every 2024/25 regular. **Which player would you look up first?**

Colin Spelman

Data: FBref / Opta · Transfermarkt via worldfootballR